

⚡ RAPID DOWNLOAD #6: CONSEQUENCES

🕒 <1 MIN

Read this the first time the MC delivers Consequences.

As we said, after each of your player actions, if you ignore a Threat or if your roll generated Consequences, I (the MC) will deliver these Consequences as story complications. Sometimes these will be things that happen in the scene, such as a key character getting away. Other times, I'll use Effects – giving and removing tags and statuses – to reflect these complications.

If you choose to deliver Consequences that involve statuses, continue to **Rapid Download #7: Statuses** (page 103). If you choose to deliver Consequences that involves story tags or burning tags, continue to **Rapid Download #8: Story Tags & Tag Effects** (page 110).

Read this the first time the MC asks a player to roll to

Mitigate Consequences with Effects:

When I (the MC) deliver Consequences that impose statuses or story tags on your character, or take away your positive statuses, story tags, or power tags, I will also rule if the situation and your tags allow you to **Mitigate** these Consequences.

Mitigating is a player reaction that works similarly to an action: you narrate how your character mitigates the Consequences, count your Power, and roll. On a miss, you take all Consequences as I delivered them. On a hit, mixed or strong, you can spend your Power to reduce the Consequences. On a strong hit, you gain 1 additional Power to spend on reducing the Consequences.

You may spend 1 point of Power to block one status tier I give or take away from you, or 2 points of Power to block one tag I give or take away from you.

🔧 HACKING DEEPER

After the player action was resolved, the MC announces the **Consequences** if any of the following conditions are met:

- **The player's action triggered Consequences** for any reason (through narrative or by rolling a miss or a mixed hit).
- There is an **unaddressed Threat** in the scene, which now materializes. This can affect any PC or NPC, not just the one who acted, but usually it involves the most imminent threat to the PC that just acted.

Unlike player actions, the MC never rolls the dice to deliver Consequences. The Consequences of each Challenge are determined by the MC, with Challenge Profiles recommending specific Consequences appropriate to the Challenge.

There is no limitation on how many Consequences the MC can deliver, or how severe. The MC chooses what happens based on the action that led to the Consequences, how badly it failed (7-9 Consequences may be less severe than

6- Consequences), the Threat that materialized, if any, and her cinematic considerations.

Like player actions, Consequences can be **Narrative** or have **Effects**. If the MC chooses to deal Consequences with Effects, she must also decide whether the PC can reasonably defend themselves from those Consequences, and if so, ask the PC to roll to **mitigate** them.

NARRATIVE CONSEQUENCES

Narrative Consequences are a powerful tool in the hands of the MC to propel the story forward. They cannot be resisted by the PCs; once a narrative Consequence is rolled out, it is already too late to prevent or mitigate it. On the other hand, narrative Consequences cannot harm the PCs directly, but rather set the scene in a new way, usually unfavorable to the PCs.

- **Escalate the Situation:** The MC describes how the situation becomes more complicated for the PCs, or how the stakes are now higher. (The Melecron AI detects the presence of the PCs' digital avatars, raising the alarm; the spirit summoned by the PC gets out of hand and starts sucking the life out of bystanders.)
- **Present a New Challenge:** The MC describes a new Challenge entering the scene, which is likely to make things harder for the PCs. (Agents of the Corporate Investigative Branch arrive at the gala looking for one of the PCs; the bipedal tank releases a swarm of flying micro-drones.)
- **Deny Them Something They Want:** The MC describes how a person, an item, or an achievement that the PCs want or need is no longer available or within reach, whether permanently or within the scope of this scene. Usually, this does not lead to a full dead end and the players will get another chance to get what they want, but it'll have to happen in a future scene and might require a new approach. (The PC drops the Source they have been hunting for down a canyon chasm; the witness that the PCs needed to clear their name is discovered dead.)
- **Make the Future Bleaker:** The MC describes how something tragic, such as a sudden death, a break-up, or a random theft, takes place around the PCs or in their lives. This development does not directly endanger the characters, but instead emphasizes the main themes of your Megacity: life is cheap, the poor get sidelined, nothing has meaning except what you make of it. Use this just when things start to get better, to reinforce the bleakness of the setting. (A recovering addict saved by the PCs goes back to their drug of choice and overdoses; a corporation that was driven out of the neighborhood by the crew starts a new, successful marketing campaign using a different logo, and people fall for it.)

CONSEQUENCES WITH EFFECTS

Similarly to player actions, Consequences can combine a narration with game Effects. Unlike player actions, however, the MC does not need to spend Power on Effects and instead simply chooses which Effects and what degree of Effects are appropriate for the Consequences being delivered. Challenge Profiles list the Effects of the Consequences they commonly deliver but the MC can alter them or come up with new Effects on the fly.

The Effects the MC can use are:

- **Give or increase a status,** choosing its tag and tier, or how many tiers to increase it
- **Reduce or remove a status,** choosing how many tiers to decrease it
- Give a story tag
- Remove or burn a story tag or a power tag

Most commonly, the MC can use these Effects in the following ways:

- Impede or harm the PCs, their allies, or their assets
 - » Give the PCs a harmful status
 - » Give the PCs a compelling status
 - » Give the PCs a hindering tag or status
 - » Burn or remove the PCs' power tags, story tags, or statuses
- Empower Challenges
 - » Give a Challenge a story tag describing a new ability
 - » Create new object or being with story tags (that are harmful to the PCs)
 - » Give a Challenge a helpful status
 - » Reduce a harmful status on a Challenge or recover a Challenge's lost tags
- Advance or delay a process
 - » Increase a progress status that is bad for the PCs
 - » Decrease a progress status that is good for the PCs

There are no Consequence Effects that are equivalent to the players' **Extra Feat** Effect. Any extra actions taken by Challenges are simply additional Consequences. There is also no equivalent Consequence Effect to the players' **Discover** Effect. If an NPC discovers something important about the PCs that affects the PCs negatively, it is considered as **Escalating the Situation**.

The MC should not cancel out the player's Effects on the same action they were created. On a 7-9, or any other situation where the player rolled a hit and chose Effects and then the MC delivers Consequences, the MC should never use their Consequences Effects to immediately negate or reduce the Effects just chosen by the player. However, the MC can use the Effects to undo different player Effects created in previous actions, for example, have an enemy Theurgist banish the PC's summoned spirit.

Examples for Consequences with Effects:

- The hacker PC was tagged by the authorities, which will make future hacks harder. The MC gives that PC a negative status, *tagged-3*.
- A nightclub bouncer embarrasses a socialite PC in front of all the club goers, throwing the PC off their game. The MC burns the *smooth operator* tag belonging to that PC.
- A strike team attacking the PCs has a hidden sniper, who shoots one of the PCs. The MC gives that PC a negative status, *wounded-5*.
- A patrol drone has been alerted to the PCs presence and is now scanning the area. The MC gives the drone the status *alert-2*.
- While the PCs are in a bar fight with a crew of rugged mercenaries, one mercenary picks up a bottle and smashes it on the bar. The MC gives the mercenary a *broken bottle* tag.

MITIGATING EFFECTS

When a PC would take an unwanted Effect due to Consequences, and **only if the PC has some ability to lessen the effects**, the MC may allow them to try and do so. (This is not applicable to narrative Consequences, which cannot be mitigated.) The MC can allow the same mitigation roll as an interjection whenever a PC takes an unwanted Effect, such as due to Specials or another player's action targeting that PC (Player vs Player).

This could represent a PC dodging attacks or soaking them up with armor; brushing off social disgrace or an opponent's negotiation tactic; resisting fear, emotions, or manipulation; dispelling magic; enduring poison or chemicals; activating measures to prevent programs from adversely affecting their console or brain; avoiding being thrown off-balance or restrained; and so on.

To mitigate an Effect, the player(s) of the affected PC(s) momentarily gets the spotlight and takes a **mitigating reaction**, which follows the same rules of player actions: they narrate how they avoid or withstand the unwanted Effect, count their Power, and roll the dice.

No other type of action can be taken during this reactive phase. For example, if the PC wants to attack, they must wait until they have the spotlight again in the player action phase. There is no limit to how many reactions a player can take to mitigate incoming Effects while they are not in the spotlight, except what is deemed feasible in the narrative by the MC.

The mitigating reaction has a different set of outcomes than other player actions:

- **6 or less (6-)** is a **miss**. The PC failed to mitigate the Effects and bears their full brunt. All the Effects dealt by the MC are applied.
- **7-9** is a **mixed hit**. The player can spend their Power to mitigate the Effects.
- **10 or higher (10+)** is a **strong hit**. The player can increase their Power by 1 before spending it to mitigate the Effects and can also use reactive Effects (see **Power Options**, page 121).

The same rules for player actions apply to mitigating actions:

- **Only Relevant Tags:** Only tags that are directly helpful or impeding in avoiding the incoming Effects affect the Power of this roll.
- **No Double Dipping:** Tags used in the player action that led to this Consequence cannot be used again to mitigate the Consequence.
- **Rule of Minimum One:** Even if the player rolls to mitigate with a Power of zero or less, they still get 1 Power to mitigate with on a 7-9 and 2 Power to mitigate with on a 10+.

SPENDING POWER TO MITIGATE EFFECTS

On a 7-9 or 10+, the player can spend their mitigating action's Power on the **Mitigate** Effect, reducing incoming Effects. Normally, a PC can only mitigate Effects that apply to them. The Power cost for **Mitigate** is as follows:

- 1 Power to remove one status tier before the status is applied. The status can be reduced to zero in this way, in which case it is ignored entirely.
- 1 Power to prevent the removal of one status tier
- 2 Power to prevent one negative tag from being added
- 2 Power to prevent one positive tag from being burned (power tag or story tag)

A PC may only spend their Power to mitigate the current batch of Effects; they cannot use it to remove previously received Consequences. To remove previous Consequences, a PC must take action separately to **Restore** the tags and/or statuses (e.g., heal a *wound* or cheer up a *despaired* ally). Any excess Power not used to mitigate the current Consequences is ignored (see an exception to this under **Power Options**, page 12).

For example, if a PC previously received *wounded-2* and has just received Consequences with an additional *wounded-3*, they can only mitigate the incoming *wounded-3*, even if they mitigate with more than 3 Power.

PLAYER VS. PLAYER

Sometimes, a PC might take action against another PC. In such cases, the same game rules are used, with a few small changes:

Establish: Players never use the Establish phase to make Threats with their PCs against other PCs. All actions performed by PCs are resolved as usual as player actions.

Player Action: The player of the PC who has the spotlight narrates, rolls, and chooses Effects for their actions, with the MC adjudicating, as usual. Instead of applying Effects to a Challenge, the chosen Effects are applied to the target PC. For example, a PC may **Attack** to impose a harmful status on the target PC or burn one of the target PC's power tags with **Weaken**.

Consequences: Players never deliver Consequences. If there are Consequences to the action, the MC can choose what they are and who they apply to, as usual.

Mitigation: The target PC can try to mitigate Effects imposed on them by the spotlight PC. The spotlight PC can try to mitigate the Effects of the MC's Consequences, if any, as usual.

Once the spotlight PC's action is completely resolved, the scene is re-established as usual. The MC may then give the target PC the spotlight, which they may use to retaliate, reversing the roles.

FOR THE MC: YOUR ARSENAL OF CONSEQUENCES

In a scene, Consequences can come from the Challenges at hand (whether or not they made a Threat) and from the PCs' own actions going awry, backfiring, or creating side effects.

CONSEQUENCES FROM CHALLENGES

- **An Asset:** The Asset may be harmed, killed, destroyed, or taken.
Possible Effects: Give the Asset a harmful status.
- **An Attacker:** The Attacker lands an attack.
Possible Effects: Give the target (usually a PC) a harmful status, or burn tags representing a disabled ability or ruined equipment.
- **A Barrier or Hazard:** The Barrier becomes tougher, alerts other Challenges, or harms those who interact with it.
Possible Effects: Give itself a positive status, give someone a harmful status.
- **A Countdown:** The countdown advances, or it ends and something dramatic happens.
Possible Effects: Give itself a progress status (see page 109).
- **A Mystery:** Information becomes harder to unveil or is now completely out of reach.
Possible Effects: Give itself a difficulty status, e.g. a witness becomes tight-lipped-3.
- **A Pursuer:** The Pursuer comes closer to the PCs, or reaches them.
Possible Effects: Reduces the tier of the distance status between them.
- **A Target:** The Target is getting further away from the PCs, or flees them entirely.
Possible Effects: Increase the tier of the distance status between them.
- **A Temptation:** The Temptation presents a compelling argument or offer.
Possible Effects: Give the PC a compelling status (see page 108).
- **A Watcher:** The Watcher finds the PCs or discovers something about them (their location, their identity, their intentions, their plan of action, etc.).
Possible Effects: Give the Watcher an **alert** status.

CONSEQUENCES FROM PLAYER ACTIONS

- **Collateral damage:** The action of the PC unintentionally affects something or someone that the PC did not want to affect.
Possible Effects: Give an ally a negative status or burn its tags.
- **Divulging information:** While taking the action, the PC betrays vital information to their adversaries (their location, their identity, their intentions, their plan of action, etc.)
Possible Effects: Narrative only, or give the adversary an advantageous status.
- **Expenditure:** The PC expends resources (stamina, ammo, magic, etc.) in the process of taking the action.
Possible Effects: Give the PC a negative status or burn their tags.
- **Exposure to a new threat:** In the process of taking the action, the PC came under a new Threat from an existing or new Challenge.
Possible Effects: Narrative only, or give the PCs a negative surprise status.
- **Harm:** The PC was harmed during the course of their action.
Possible Effects: Give the PC a harmful status.
- **Imperfect execution:** The PC didn't get everything they wanted out of the action, e.g., information is incomplete, a spell has only some of the intended effects, etc.
Possible Effects: Narrative only.
- **Loss of advantage:** The PC lost an advantage they previously had or worked to achieve.
Possible Effects: Narrative (especially countering a previous quick outcome or Extra Feat), remove a beneficial status, or burn a beneficial tag.
- **Side effects:** The PC's action had unexpected or unwanted results.
Possible Effects: Narrative only, give them a negative tag or status, or create an impeding tag in the scene.
- **Wasted Time:** The PC spent too much time on this action, missing other opportunities or opening themselves to nearby danger.
Possible Effects: Present a New Challenge, Deny Them Something They Want, Escalate The Situation, or advance a time-related progress status (such as a ticking bomb).

LETTING THE PLAYER CHOOSE BETWEEN CONSEQUENCES

Good games are about choices. You can create an interesting choice for your players by making them choose between two or more Consequences for their action. For example:

- Take a shot meant for an ally or let them get hit
- Leave evidence at the scene or alert the guards to your presence
- Expend more magical energy or have the spirit you bound break free

OPTIONAL RULE: CONSEQUENCES FROM WEAKNESS TAGS

By default, weakness tags can only be invoked by the MC to completely rule out certain actions (respect the tag, **Handling Tags**, page 89) or to reduce the Power of a player action before making a roll. However, sometimes weakness tags represent issues, limitations, or flaws that can actively harm the PC rather than merely hinder their actions.

This optional rule allows the MC to invoke a weakness tag after the player's roll during the Consequence phase in order to deliver Consequences. This makes invoking weakness tags the third possible generator of Consequences (together with unaddressed Threats and the outcome of the player's roll). Whenever the MC invokes a weakness tag to deliver Consequences, the player marks an upgrade box on the tag's theme, the same as they would if the weakness tag was invoked during a roll.

For example, after a PC who is carrying a firearm with a **short magazine** fires it several times, the MC can deliver the Consequence of running out of ammo (**Escalate The Situation** or give a status). The player would then mark an upgrade box on that theme and presumably the PC would have to take action to reload before firing again. For a character whose Source **attracts demons**, the MC could invoke the weakness tag normally whenever the PC is attempting to sneak past demons, reducing the action's Power. Using this rule, she can also deliver Consequences whenever the character is near demons to reveal one of them was attracted by the Source and is now accosting the PC (**Present a New Challenge**). In either case, the player marks an upgrade box on the weakness tag's theme.